

FOR SUPPLIERS & SMEs

Asked for sustainability data?

A supplier's response pack

Whether you have to respond, the value-chain cap that protects smaller firms, the VSME standard, and three copy-paste email templates you can send today. Post-Omnibus, plain English, free.

Do you even have to respond?

Short answer: if your company has **fewer than 1,000 employees**, a customer that is in CSRD scope **cannot require** you to provide more sustainability data than the voluntary **VSME** standard contains. This is the “value-chain cap.” You can share VSME-level data to keep the relationship healthy, and decline anything beyond it.

The value-chain cap

A protection in the Omnibus directive (Directive (EU) 2026/470). Companies in CSRD scope may not demand sustainability information beyond the VSME standard from value-chain partners with fewer than 1,000 employees. It stops the reporting burden trickling down onto smaller firms the CSRD deliberately left out of scope.

What is VSME?

The Voluntary Sustainability Reporting Standard for SMEs, developed by EFRAG. A much shorter, simpler standard than the full ESRS, built for smaller companies not in mandatory CSRD scope. It is also the ceiling for what in-scope companies can ask of sub-1,000-employee partners.

Are you actually in scope yourself? You are in mandatory CSRD scope only if you exceed **both** thresholds: more than 1,000 employees **and** more than EUR 450 million net turnover. If you meet both, you are a reporter, not just a requestee - check the free scope checker at csrd-tools.com/scope-checker. If you do not, the value-chain cap protects you.

Three copy-paste response templates

Swap in the [bracketed] details for your situation, then send. Pick the one that matches your position.

Template 1: You are a small supplier (under 1,000 employees)

Use when a customer sends a long questionnaire and your company has fewer than 1,000 employees.

SUBJECT Our response to your CSRD / sustainability data request

Hi [Contact name],

Thanks for your sustainability data request. We want to help you meet your reporting obligations, so here is where we stand.

Our company has fewer than 1,000 employees. Under the CSRD as amended by the Omnibus directive, companies in your reporting scope may not require value-chain partners below 1,000 employees to provide more sustainability information than the voluntary VSME standard sets out. This is often called the "value-chain cap."

On that basis:

- We are happy to share the data points covered by the VSME standard (basic module).
- For anything beyond VSME, we may not be able to provide it, and are not required to.

If you can point us to which of your questions map to VSME, we will fill those in promptly. If it helps, we are glad to send what we already track on energy, emissions and headcount.

Happy to talk it through.

[Your name]
[Your company]

Template 2: You will share VSME-level data

Use to offer the data you can reasonably provide, on your terms, in a structured way.

SUBJECT Sustainability data we can provide (VSME basis)

Hi [Contact name],

Following up on your request. Here is what we can share, set out against the voluntary VSME standard so it slots into your reporting:

- General: business model, headcount, locations.
- Environment: energy use, Scope 1 and Scope 2 emissions where we have them, water and waste basics.
- Social: number of employees, health-and-safety incidents, basic workforce figures.
- Governance: any convictions or fines for corruption or bribery (none, in our case).

We have used our best available figures and flagged any estimates. If you need a specific format or reporting period, send it over and we will fill it in.

For data points outside the VSME standard, please note the value-chain cap applies to us as a company with fewer than 1,000 employees.

Best regards,
[Your name]
[Your company]

Template 3: Ask the customer to narrow the request

Use when the questionnaire is huge, generic, or clearly built for a large reporter.

SUBJECT Quick question on your sustainability data request

Hi [Contact name],

Thanks for sending the sustainability questionnaire. Before we invest time in it, could you help us scope it correctly?

We are a smaller company (fewer than 1,000 employees). Under the CSRD value-chain cap, companies in reporting scope can ask partners our size only for data within the voluntary VSME standard, not the full ESRS data set. A lot of the questions in your form look like full-ESRS items.

Could you let us know:

1. Which questions you actually need from a supplier of our size?
2. Whether the VSME basic module would meet your needs?
3. The reporting period and format you need?

Once we know that, we will turn the relevant answers around quickly. We would rather give you accurate VSME-level data than guess at items that do not apply to us.

Thanks,
[Your name]
[Your company]

Good to know

Do not feel rushed. You can ask for a reasonable deadline and the exact list of data points before committing time.

Keep a record. Save your response and the request. If you state you are below the 1,000-employee threshold and rely on the value-chain cap, note it.

Watch for change. The revised (simplified) ESRS and the VSME standard are still being finalised and apply from FY2027. We track the moving parts at csrd-tools.com - join The CSRD Brief for plain-English alerts when this changes.

This pack is general guidance to help suppliers respond to sustainability data requests under the CSRD. It is not legal advice. Confirm specifics against the VSME standard, the Omnibus directive (Directive (EU) 2026/470) and the official EFRAG and European Commission sources, or with a qualified adviser. (c) 2026 CSRD Tools.